centre for pediatric emergencies and specialized care

Eczema Care

You (your child) have just received dermatologic care for eczema and a prescription was sent to your pharmacy for topical steroids. Here are general principles to accompany the prescription and help maximize effectiveness of care needed.

WHAT IS A FINGERTIP UNIT (FTU)?



- One FTU is the amount of topical steroid that is squeezed out from a standard tube along an adult's *fingertip*.
- A fingertip is from the very end of the finger to the first crease in the finger.
- One FTU is *enough* to treat an area of skin twice (2x) the size of a "handprint" i.e. the flat of an adult hand with the fingers together.
- If you are the parent of a child, you can assess the amount of topical steroid to use by using your (adult) hand to measure the amount of skin affected on the child. From this you can work out the amount of topical steroid to use based on an FTU= 2x adult handprint.
    - Example: if your child's eczema covers 4 adult handprints of surface area, will require 2 FTUs of steroid cream.

WHAT ESTIMATED AMOUNT OF FTUs ARE USUALLY NEEDED?

	<1 year old	1-2 years old	3-5 years old	6-10 years old	11-17 years old
Face and neck	1	1.5	1.5	2	3
Arm and hand	1	1.5	2	2.5	3
Leg and foot	1.5	1.5	3	4.5	4
Chest & Abdomen (front)	1	1	3	3.5	3
Back and buttocks	1.5	1.5	3.5	5	5

WHEN DO I STOP APPLYING THE STEROID CREAM?

- Most physicians prescribe to apply the steroid cream during an "eczema flare" (defined as when red and itchy) for at least two (2) weeks or until better / resolved.
- However, ideal not to stop suddenly. Once improved, apply to the affected areas every other day for another two (2) weeks and then stop.
- Variations of above may be counselled by your doctor.

WHEN DO I STOP APPLYING THE MOISTURIZER CREAM?

- Never. It is crucial to ensure the skin is always hydrated. Doing this as often as possible will help prevent eczema flares.

*The recommendations provided in this document are based provided here are based on general knowledge and experience in the field. However, the educational material contained herein is NOT a substitute for clinical judgment that is required to meet the different needs of individual patients.